In 1912, the year in which Foote died, the German geologist Alfred Wegener published *The Origin of Continents and Oceans*, which was in its own field as radical as Darwin's *On the Origin of Species*. Wegener argued that hundreds of millions of years ago the Earth's outer shell had formed one huge land-mass which had then broken apart: the theory of continental drift. For the better part of half a century his theory remained just that, for want of proof – until the discovery in the 1950s that the ocean sea-floors were expanding, giving rise to the concept of tectonic plate movement.

The most spectacular example of continental drift and tectonic plate movement has to be the Indian Plate, a triangle of geomorphic crust which aeons ago broke away from the single supercontinent of Gondwanaland to drift north-eastwards across the globe. As it slid so it scraped over magmatic hotspots, releasing stupendous amounts of volcanic gases and lava – a catastrophic venting that may well have contributed towards the extinction of the greater dinosaurs but most certainly created the layers of thick lava topped by granite boulders that make up much of the triangular tableland known as the Indian Plate, which the Arya (of whom I have a lot more to say in a later chapter) named the Deccan (derived from the Sanskrit *dakshina*, 'south country').

This triangular tableland is the first India, the original. Northern India came after, only taking shape after the Indian Plate had collided with the Eurasian Plate. By a process of subduction this still ongoing collision first undermined and lifted what is now the Tibetan Plateau and then buckled, giving rise to the Himalayas. As the waters drained off this new plateau in one vast proto-Ganges so the great trough between the two land-masses filled with sediment 6 miles deep, to become the Gangetic and Indus plains.